

decorative stonework details, the building is long and low—only two stories high—but has vertical elements provided by nine voluted gables that project boldly up and outward. The facades at both ends feature similarly sumptuous gabling, arranged over five bands. But the Exchange's most distinctive feature is the copper-sheathed spire, 184 ft (56 m) high, which rests on an open-sided lantern in the center of the steeply pitched copper roof. It comprises four entwined dragons' tails that spiral exotically upward.

Les Invalides

Location Paris, France

Les Invalides was begun by Louis XIV in 1670 as part hospital, part home for the veteran soldiers of

France. Among the most ambitious urban projects of the Baroque period, it is a vast complex of 17 stately courtyards in the heart of Paris. Its most imposing feature is the church of the Dôme des Invalides—from 1840, the site of Napoleon's tomb—designed by Jules Hardouin-Mansart. Its two-story facade, separated by a pronounced entablature, features clusters of columns under a projecting pediment. From this rises a double-drum, with pairs of projecting columns below and volutes above. It supports the most dramatic dome in France, glistening with gold ribs and trophies of arms, from which a slim, gold-and-green spire thrusts 351 ft (107 m) above the city.

▼ THE SPRAWLING COMPLEX OF LES INVALIDES

Zwinger

Location Dresden, Germany

The Zwinger palace—built between 1710 and 1728, then rebuilt after World War II—is perhaps the most outlandish structure in Europe. In its different guises as a courtly arena, pleasure garden, art gallery, and theater, it exudes exuberance. It was built for the Saxon Elector Augustus the Strong by his court architect, Matthäus Daniel Pöppelmann. It is essentially an arcaded courtyard, with four fountains at its center, formed by low galleries interrupted by larger buildings. Two sides are apsed. In the center of three of its sides are entry pavilions of startling originality—part Baroque, part Rococo. The whole building is festooned with architectural and sculptural decorations.

Abbey Church

Location Weltenberg, Germany

The unremarkable exterior of the Abbey Church at Weltenberg, on the banks of the Danube, promises little. By contrast, the interior marks the first great example of one of the Rococo's most distinctive qualities—the fusion of painting, sculpture, and architecture—in an ingenious spatial plan. Built in 1717–1721, the church is the work of the Asam brothers, Egid Quirin and Cosmas Damian. Despite the lavishness of the oval nave, with its paired columns, the main focus is on the gilt and silvered equestrian statue of St. George, over the high altar, slaying a dragon. From the hidden light sources to the twisting barley-sugar columns that frame the altar, the impact is compellingly theatrical.

